framework assumes that specialists within a particular 'policy subsystem' play an important role in most of the policy-making.[19] The behavior of these specialists is affected by the broader socioeconomic and political system. The framework further assumes that the individual is heavily impacted by social psychology and that multiple actors in a subsystem should be aggregated into advocacy coalitions. These assumptions are determined by the relationship between the dependent variables i.e. 'belief systems' and 'policy change' and the independent variables i.e. 'policy-oriented learning' and 'external shocks', as well as 'negotiated agreements'.[20] The belief system, here, is a three-tier system that includes core beliefs, policy core beliefs, and secondary beliefs.

Core beliefs refer to ontological and normative assumptions about human behavior and the weight given to basic values such as equality and welfare of people. An outcome of social conditioning that a person undergoes from childhood, core beliefs are considered as difficult to change. Policy core beliefs, on the other hand, are the application of deep core beliefs by policy participants within a policy subsystem. While there is no direct relation or one-to-one correspondence between deep core beliefs and policy core beliefs, policies are often an outcome of deep-rooted beliefs. India's investment in economic projects in different African, South Asian, and Latin American countries, for instance, is based on the core belief of many policy participants that economic investment across the world by private and public firms is a positive thing to do. The core belief that investment is good, then determines policy core beliefs that determine how to go about formulating investment strategies and locating areas for potential investment.

Different sets of policy core beliefs help in identifying different advocacy coalitions within a given policy subsystem. While looking at US foreign policy in Iraq, for example, different advocacy coalitions could be identified based on which actor is advocating what—while some actors would have advocated the use of force, others would have advocated diplomacy or economic sanctions. However, it is possible that in some policy subsystems hugely divergent preferences—which are called 'policy core policy preferences'—lead to intransigent debates.[21] These preferences can be subsystem-wide in scope, very salient, and create long-term fissures within a policy subsystem. Secondary beliefs,